

### READER TIP:

*Over the last five years, we have reduced our grocery budget to \$300 a month for a family of four. It is definitely a challenge as food prices continue to increase. Learning to view meat as an add-in or side instead of a main course has been the biggest help. That, and cutting out most prepared or prepackaged foods and cooking them from scratch.*

—Lisa, TX

## 5. SHOP IN BULK

There's some debate on whether warehouse club memberships (think Sam's, BJ's, or Costco) are actually worth it, but I believe they are. However, just like anything else you spend money on, you have to be smart when shopping these kinds of stores.

Start by checking each store's prices before making a final commitment. Find a friend or family member with a card, and write down the prices of your favorite items, as well as the unit cost, to determine whether or not each item is indeed cheaper than your regular or discount grocery store. You may also want to consider going in with a friend to share the yearly cost.

It is also important to remember expiration dates. Bulk foods are fantastic for pantry items that last for months, but beware of refrigerated items that can't be frozen. You don't want to trade savings for food waste!

## 6. USE COUPONS

I am definitely *not* an extreme couponer—sometimes I will go weeks without clipping a single piece of paper. However, when I do take the time to put together a strategic shopping list and match it up with store sales and coupons, I notice a pretty big difference in my grocery bill for weeks to come.